

Yarno Ritzen

Investigative Journalist · OSINT & Visual Investigations

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PROFILE

Award-winning investigative journalist with eleven years at Al Jazeera — the last six inside the Investigative Unit, after earlier producer roles on the digital news desk and interactive department. IRE-winning, BAFTA-nominated work combining satellite imagery analysis, geolocation and chronolocation, ship and aircraft tracking, and exclusive confidential datasets to produce accountability journalism across Asia, Africa, Europe and the Middle East. Solo reporter on self-conceived investigations and collaborator on team projects — comfortable delivering all-formats journalism in text, long-form video and interactive output, end-to-end.

SELECTED INVESTIGATIONS

Africa's Ghost Reporters — Al Jazeera Investigations (solo byline), March 2025

Exposed a Russia-linked influence campaign using 15+ fictitious journalists and at least 200 paid-for articles seeded across Francophone Africa to amplify anti-French, pro-Russian narratives. Identified the stolen identity behind the lead persona — a deceased Central African teacher — via reverse image analysis; surfaced Cyrillic strings and a Russian phone number inside Word-document metadata; reverse-traced the number to a former Internet Research Agency operator with Wagner Group ties. Published as a long-form text feature and a 25-minute documentary.

Somalia E-Visa Security Exposure — Al Jazeera Investigations (solo byline), December 2025

Probed Somalia's new electronic-visa portal and found a security flaw that left passport details of thousands of applicants downloadable to anyone who knew where to look. Verified the exposed data and responsibly disclosed before publication.

The Island of Secrets — IRE Award (Video, Division 1), 2021

Self-conceived visual investigation revealing India's covert military build-out on the Mauritian atoll of Agaléga. Combined commercial satellite imagery across multi-year time series, vessel-tracking data and rare on-island sourcing to reconstruct the project and its strategic intent. Published as long-form video and written feature.

Facebook Pages of Hate — Lovie Awards (Gold, News & Politics; Bronze, Best Use of Stories), 2020

Identified and documented 120+ neo-Nazi and far-right music pages on Facebook with 800,000+ combined likes, built as a structured inventory of pages and networks across the platform.

Al Jazeera Investigative Unit — collaborative contributions

- All the Prime Minister's Men (Amnesty Media Award, 2022) — OSINT on financial and corporate trails of a sitting head of government. Solo follow-up exclusive (Dec 2022) revealed UK spy-training trips by a paramilitary unit later sanctioned for human-rights abuses; the named former army chief was sanctioned by the US Treasury in 2024.
- The Gold Mafia (2023) — multi-part series exposing Zimbabwean state-linked gold smuggling, money laundering and sanctions evasion; triggered government inquiries.
- The Men Who Sell Football (RTS Award; BAFTA nomination, 2022) — entity tracing across intermediaries and front companies.
- The Cyprus Papers (BAFTA nomination; Webby Awards, 2021) — analysis of leaked records to identify high-risk individuals granted EU passports.
- Diplomats for Sale & Anatomy of a Bribe (NY TV & Film Awards, 2020) — undercover and OSINT components on diplomatic-passport schemes and bribery networks.

EXPERIENCE

Producer — Al Jazeera Investigative Unit

Doha, Qatar · Dec 2019 – Present

- Conceive, report and write OSINT-led investigations end-to-end — solo bylines and team contributions — using satellite imagery analysis, geolocation and chronolocation of photos and video, vessel and aircraft tracking, and structured analysis of large, unstructured datasets.
- Cross-reference leaked and acquired confidential datasets — building entity/link networks across people, companies, properties and movements to surface hidden relationships.
- Partner with investigative reporters, correspondents, video producers and graphics colleagues to deliver exclusives across text, long-form video and digital formats; also write breaking-news and impact follow-ups between major projects.
- Cultivate and protect high-value human sources; operate the unit's secure intake (SecureDrop) and encrypted communications; coordinate digital-security posture with IT.
- Own the unit's written output for Aljazeera.com and Ajiunit.com — from breaking-news reactions to long-form features and documentary scripts.
- Build bespoke editorial tools — scrapers, monitors and structured data pipelines — using AI-assisted coding workflows (Claude Code, Gemini CLI) to scale repeatable OSINT tasks and surface signal from noisy public-web sources.

Producer — Al Jazeera Digital News Desk

Doha, Qatar · Jul 2017 – Sep 2019

- Reported and wrote breaking news, features, explainers and background pieces in a fast-paced, global newsroom.
- Identified original story angles and reworked agency copy to fit Al Jazeera's editorial voice.

Assistant Producer — Al Jazeera Interactive Department

Doha, Qatar · Aug 2014 – Jun 2017

- Built data-driven infographics and interactive web productions embedded in long-form journalism.
- Explored emerging visual storytelling: 360-degree video, VR and gamified explainers. Multiple Online Media and Webby recognitions with the team.

Producer (intern) — NU.nl

Hoofddorp, Netherlands · Aug – Dec 2013

- Data journalism, infographics, and original news reporting.

OSINT TOOLBOX

- **Visual investigations:** satellite imagery (commercial providers; change detection across time series), geolocation and chronolocation of photos and video, image and video verification, cartographic visualisation for investigative stories.
- **Movement tracking:** maritime (AIS, port records) and aviation (ADS-B) tracking; cross-referencing with corporate and shipping records.
- **Data investigations:** link analysis and entity resolution across large, unstructured and confidential datasets; cross-jurisdictional asset and corporate tracing.
- **Source protection & digital security:** SecureDrop, end-to-end encryption, OPSEC for sources and reporters.
- **Custom tooling & AI:** build editorial scrapers, monitors and data pipelines using AI-assisted coding (Claude Code, Gemini CLI); comfortable on the command line and working from engineer-built systems through to bespoke CMSes.
- **Storytelling:** news writing, long-form features, documentary scripts, explainers, and interactive web productions.

EDUCATION

B.A. Journalism — Utrecht University of Applied Sciences, Netherlands.

LANGUAGES

Dutch (fluent) · **English** (fluent) · **German** (reading proficiency) · **French** (reading proficiency)

REFERENCES

Available on request — strong references from former managers at Al Jazeera, Thomson Reuters Foundation and Amnesty International UK.